THE PROPOSAL

A Jest in One Act by
Anton Chekhov
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The scene is laid at CHUBUKOV’s country-house

A drawing-room in CHUBUKOV’S house.

LOMOV enters, wearing a dress-jacket and white gloves. CHUBUKOV rises to meet him.

CHUBUKOV
My dear fellow, whom do I see! Ivan Vassilevitch! I am extremely glad!
(Squeezes his hand)
Now this is a surprise, my darling... How are you?

LOMOV
Thank you. And how may you be getting on?

CHUBUKOV
We just get along somehow, my angel, to your prayers, and so on. Sit down, please do.... Now, you know, you shouldn’t forget all about your neighbours, my darling. My dear fellow, why are you so formal in your get-up? Evening dress, gloves, and so on. Can you be going anywhere, my treasure?

LOMOV
No, I’ve come only to see you, honoured Stepan Stepanovitch.

CHUBUKOV
Then why are you in evening dress, my precious? As if you’re paying a New Year’s Eve visit!

LOMOV
Well, you see, it’s like this.
(Takes his arm)
I’ve come to you, honoured Stepan Stepanovitch, to trouble you with a request. Not once or twice have I already had the privilege of applying to you for help, and you have always, so to speak... I must ask your pardon, I am getting excited. I shall drink some water, honoured Stepan Stepanovitch.

Drinks.

CHUBUKOV
(Aside)
He's come to borrow money! Shan't give him any!
(Aloud)
What is it, my beauty?

LOMOV
You see, Honour Stepanitch... I beg pardon, Stepan Honouritch... I mean, I'm awfully excited, as you will please notice.... In short, you alone can help me, though I don't deserve it, of course... and haven't any right to count on your assistance....

CHUBUKOV
Oh, don't go round and round it, darling! Spit it out! Well?

LOMOV
One moment... this very minute. The fact is, I've come to ask the hand of your daughter, Natalya Stepanovna, in marriage.

CHUBUKOV
(Joyfully)
By Jove! Ivan Vassilevitch! Say it again—I didn't hear it all!

LOMOV
I have the honour to ask...

CHUBUKOV
(Interrupting)
My dear fellow... I'm so glad, and so on.... Yes, indeed, and all that sort of thing.
(Embraces and kisses LOMOV)
I've been hoping for it for a long time. It's been my continual desire.
(Sheds a tear)
And I've always loved you, my angel, as if you were my own son. May God give you both His help and His love and so on, and I did so much hope... What am I behaving in this idiotic way for? I'm off my balance with joy, absolutely off my balance! Oh, with all my soul... I'll go and call Natasha, and all that.

LOMOV
(Greatly moved)
Honoured Stepan Stepanovitch, do you think I may count on her consent?

CHUBUKOV
Why, of course, my darling, and... as if she won't consent! She's in love; egad, she's like a love-sick cat, and so on.... Shan't be long!

Exit.

LOMOV
It's cold... I'm trembling all over, just as if I'd got an examination before me. The great thing is, I must have my mind made up. If I give myself time to think, to hesitate, to talk a lot, to look for an ideal, or for real love, then I'll never get married.... Brr!... It's cold! Natalya Stepanovna is an excellent housekeeper, not bad-looking, well-educated.... What more do I want? But I'm getting a noise in my ears from excitement.
(Drinks)
And it's impossible for me not to marry.... In the first place, I'm already 35—a critical age, so to speak. In the second place, I ought to lead a quiet and regular life.... I suffer from palpitations, I'm excitable and always getting awfully upset.... At this very moment my lips are trembling, and there's a twitch in my right eyebrow.... But the very worst of all is the way I sleep. I no sooner get into bed and begin to go off when suddenly something in my left side—gives a pull, and I can feel it in my shoulder and head.... I jump up like a lunatic, walk about a bit, and lie down again, but as soon as I begin to get off to sleep there's another pull! And this may happen twenty times....

NATALYA STEPANOVNA comes in.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Well, there! It’s you, and papa said, “Go; there’s a merchant come for his goods.” How do you do, Ivan Vassilevitch!

LOMOV
How do you do, honoured Natalya Stepanovna?

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
You must excuse my apron and négligé... we’re shelling peas for drying. Why haven’t you been here for such a long time? Sit down.
(They seat themselves)
Won’t you have some lunch?

LOMOV
No, thank you, I’ve had some already.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Then smoke.... Here are the matches.... The weather is splendid now, but yesterday it was so wet that the workmen didn’t do anything all day. How much hay have you stacked? Just think, I felt greedy and had a whole field cut, and now I’m not at all pleased about it because I’m afraid my hay may rot. I ought to have waited a bit. But what’s this? Why, you’re in evening dress! Well, I never! Are you going to a ball, or what?—though I must say you look better. Tell me, why are you got up like that?

LOMOV
(Excited)
You see, honoured Natalya Stepanovna... the fact is, I’ve made up my mind to ask you to hear me out.... Of course you’ll be surprised and perhaps even angry, but a...
(Aside)
It’s awfully cold!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
What’s the matter?
(Pause)
Well?

LOMOV
I shall try to be brief. You must know, honoured Natalya Stepanovna, that I have long, since my childhood, in fact, had the privilege of knowing your family. My late aunt and her husband, from whom, as you know, I inherited my land, always had the greatest respect for your father and your late mother. The Lomovs and the Chubukovs have always had the most friendly, and I might almost say the most affectionate, regard for each other. And, as you know, my land is a near neighbour of yours. You will remember that my Oxen Meadows touch your birchwoods.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Excuse my interrupting you. You say, “my Oxen Meadows....” But are they yours?

LOMOV
Yes, mine.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
What are you talking about? Oxen Meadows are ours, not yours!

LOMOV
No, mine, honoured Natalya Stepanovna.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Well, I never knew that before. How do you make that out?

LOMOV
How? I’m speaking of those Oxen Meadows which are wedged in between your birchwoods and the Burnt Marsh.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Yes, yes.... They’re ours.

LOMOV
No, you’re mistaken, honoured Natalya Stepanovna, they’re mine.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Just think, Ivan Vassilevitch! How long have they been yours?

LOMOV
How long? As long as I can remember.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Really, you won't get me to believe that!

LOMOV
But you can see from the documents, honoured Natalya Stepanovna. Oxen Meadows, it's true, were once the subject of dispute, but now everybody knows that they are mine. There's nothing to argue about. You see, my aunt's grandmother gave the free use of these Meadows in perpetuity to the peasants of your father's grandfather, in return for which they were to make bricks for her. The peasants belonging to your father's grandfather had the free use of the Meadows for forty years, and had got into the habit of regarding them as their own, when it happened that...

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
No, it isn't at all like that! Both my grandfather and great-grandfather reckoned that their land extended to Burnt Marsh—which means that Oxen Meadows were ours. I don't see what there is to argue about. It's simply silly!

LOMOV
I'll show you the documents, Natalya Stepanovna!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
No, you're simply joking, or making fun of me.... What a surprise! We've had the land for nearly three hundred years, and then we're suddenly told that it isn't ours! Ivan Vassilevitch, I can hardly believe my own ears.... These Meadows aren't worth much to me. They only come to five dessiatins
(Note: 13.5 acres)
, and are worth perhaps 300 roubles
(Note: £30.)
, but I can't stand unfairness. Say what you will, but I can't stand unfairness.

LOMOV
Hear me out, I implore you! The peasants of your father's grandfather, as I have already had the honour of explaining to you, used to bake bricks for my aunt's grandmother. Now my aunt's grandmother, wishing to make them a pleasant...

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
I can't make head or tail of all this about aunts and grandfathers and grandmothers! The Meadows are ours, and that's all.

LOMOV
Mine.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Ours! You can go on proving it for two days on end, you can go and put on fifteen dress-jackets, but I tell you they're ours, ours, ours! I don't want anything of yours and I don't want to give up anything of mine. So there!

LOMOV
Natalya Ivanovna, I don't want the Meadows, but I am acting on principle. If you like, I'll make you a present of them.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
I can make you a present of them myself, because they're mine! Your behaviour, Ivan Vassilevitch, is strange, to say the least! Up to this we have always thought of you as a good neighbour, a friend: last year we lent you our threshing-machine, although on that account we had to put off our own threshing till November, but you behave to us as if we were gipsies. Giving me my own land, indeed! No, really, that's not at all neighbourly! In my opinion, it's even impudent, if you want to know....

LOMOV
Then you make out that I'm a land-grabber? Madam, never in my life have I grabbed anybody else's land, and I shan't allow anybody to accuse me of having done so....
(Quickly steps to the carafe and drinks more water)
Oxen Meadows are mine!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
It's not true, they're ours!

LOMOV
Mine!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
It's not true! I'll prove it! I'll send my mowers out to the Meadows this very day!

LOMOV
What?

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
My mowers will be there this very day!

LOMOV
I'll give it to them in the neck!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
You dare!

LOMOV
(Clutches at his heart)
Oxen Meadows are mine! You understand? Mine!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Please don't shout! You can shout yourself hoarse in your own house, but here I must ask you to restrain yourself!

LOMOV
If it wasn't, madam, for this awful, excruciating palpitation, if my whole inside wasn't upset, I'd talk to you in a different way!
(Yells)
Oxen Meadows are mine!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Ours!

LOMOV
Mine!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Ours!

LOMOV
Mine!

Enter CHUBUKOV.

CHUBUKOV
What's the matter? What are you shouting at?

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Papa, please tell to this gentleman who owns Oxen Meadows, we or he?

CHUBUKOV
(To LOMOV)
Darling, the Meadows are ours!

LOMOV
But, please, Stepan Stepanitch, how can they be yours? Do be a reasonable man! My aunt's grandmother gave the Meadows for the temporary and free use of your grandfather's peasants. The peasants used the land for forty years and got as accustomed to it as if it was their own, when it happened that...

CHUBUKOV
Excuse me, my precious.... You forget just this, that the peasants didn't pay your grandmother and all that, because the Meadows were in dispute, and so on. And now everybody knows that they're ours. It means that you haven't seen the plan.

LOMOV
I'll prove to you that they're mine!

CHUBUKOV
You won't prove it, my darling.

LOMOV
I shall!

CHUBUKOV
Dear one, why yell like that? You won't prove anything just by yelling. I don't want anything of yours, and don't intend to give up what I have. Why should I? And you know, my beloved, that if you propose to go on arguing about it, I'd much sooner give up the meadows to the peasants than to you. There!

LOMOV
I don't understand! How have you the right to give away somebody else's property?

CHUBUKOV
You may take it that I know whether I have the right or not. Because, young man, I'm not used to being spoken to in that tone of voice, and so on: I, young man, am twice your age, and ask you to speak to me without agitating yourself, and all that.

LOMOV
No, you just think I'm a fool and want to have me on! You call my land yours, and then you want me to talk to you calmly and politely! Good neighbours don't behave like that, Stepan Stepanitch! You're not a neighbour, you're a grabber!

CHUBUKOV
What's that? What did you say?

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Papa, send the mowers out to the Meadows at once!

CHUBUKOV
What did you say, sir?

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Oxen Meadows are ours, and I shan't give them up, shan't give them up, shan't give them up!

LOMOV
We'll see! I'll have the matter taken to court, and then I'll show you!

CHUBUKOV
To court? You can take it to court, and all that! You can! I know you; you're just on the look-out for a chance to go to court, and all that.... You pettifogger! All your people were like that! All of them!

LOMOV
Never mind about my people! The Lomovs have all been honourable people, and not one has ever been tried for embezzlement, like your grandfather!

CHUBUKOV
You Lomovs have had lunacy in your family, all of you!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
All, all, all!

CHUBUKOV
Your grandfather was a drunkard, and your younger aunt, Nastasya Mihailovna, ran away with an architect, and so on.

LOMOV
And your mother was hump-backed.
(Clutches at his heart)
Something pulling in my side.... My head.... Help! Water!

CHUBUKOV
Your father was a guzzling gambler!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
And there haven't been many backbiters to equal your aunt!

LOMOV
My left foot has gone to sleep.... You're an intriguer.... Oh, my heart!... And it's an open secret that before the last elections you bri... I can see stars.... Where's my hat?

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
It's low! It's dishonest! It's mean!

CHUBUKOV
And you're just a malicious, double-faced intriguer! Yes!

LOMOV
Here’s my hat.... My heart!... Which way? Where’s the door? Oh!... I think I’m dying.... My foot’s quite numb....

Goes to the door.

CHUBUKOV
(Following him)
And don’t set foot in my house again!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Take it to court! We’ll see!

LOMOV staggers out.

CHUBUKOV
Devil take him!

Walks about in excitement.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
What a rascal! What trust can one have in one’s neighbours after that!

CHUBUKOV
The villain! The scarecrow!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
The monster! First he takes our land and then he has the impudence to abuse us.

CHUBUKOV
And that blind hen, yes, that turnip-ghost has the confounded cheek to make a proposal, and so on! What? A proposal!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
What proposal?

CHUBUKOV
Why, he came here so as to propose to you.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
To propose? To me? Why didn’t you tell me so before?

CHUBUKOV
So he dresses up in evening clothes. The stuffed sausage! The wizen-faced frump!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
To propose to me? Ah!
(Falls into an easy-chair and wails)
Bring him back! Back! Ah! Bring him here.

CHUBUKOV
Bring whom here?

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Quick, quick! I'm ill! Fetch him!

Hysterics.

CHUBUKOV
What's that? What's the matter with you?
(Clutches at his head)
Oh, unhappy man that I am! I'll shoot myself! I'll hang myself! We've done for her!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
I'm dying! Fetch him!

CHUBUKOV
Tfoo! At once. Don't yell!

Runs out. A pause. NATALYA STEPANOVNA wails.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
What have they done to me! Fetch him back! Fetch him!

A pause.

CHUBUKOV runs in.

CHUBUKOV
He's coming, and so on, devil take him! Ouf! Talk to him yourself; I don't want to....

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
(Wails)
Fetch him!

CHUBUKOV
(Yells)
He’s coming, I tell you. Oh, what a burden, Lord, to be the father of a grown-up daughter! I’ll cut my throat! I will, indeed! We cursed him, abused him, drove him out, and it’s all you... you!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
No, it was you!

CHUBUKOV
I tell you it’s not my fault.
(LOMOV appears at the door)
Now you talk to him yourself

Exit.

LOMOV enters, exhausted.

LOMOV
My heart’s palpitating awfully.... My foot’s gone to sleep.... There’s something keeps pulling in my side.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Forgive us, Ivan Vassilevitch, we were all a little heated.... I remember now: Oxen Meadows really are yours.

LOMOV
My heart’s beating awfully.... My Meadows.... My eyebrows are both twitching....

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
The Meadows are yours, yes, yours.... Do sit down....
(They sit)
We were wrong....

LOMOV
I did it on principle.... My land is worth little to me, but the principle...

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Yes, the principle, just so.... Now let’s talk of something else.

LOMOV
The more so as I have evidence. My aunt’s grandmother gave the land to your father’s grandfather’s peasants...

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Yes, yes, let that pass....
(Aside)
I wish I knew how to get him started....
(Aloud)
Are you going to start shooting soon?

LOMOV
I’m thinking of having a go at the blackcock, honoured Natalya Stepanovna, after the harvest. Oh, have you heard? Just think, what a misfortune I’ve had! My dog Guess, whom you know, has gone lame.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
What a pity! Why?

LOMOV
I don’t know.... Must have got twisted, or bitten by some other dog....
(Sighs)
My very best dog, to say nothing of the expense. I gave Mironov 125 roubles for him.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
It was too much, Ivan Vassilevitch.

LOMOV
I think it was very cheap. He’s a first-rate dog.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Papa gave 85 roubles for his Squeezer, and Squeezer is heaps better than Guess!

LOMOV
Squeezer better than. Guess? What an idea!
(Laughs)
Squeezer better than Guess!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Of course he’s better! Of course, Squeezer is young, he may develop a bit, but on points and pedigree he’s better than anything that even Volchanetsky has got.

LOMOV
Excuse me, Natalya Stepanovna, but you forget that he is overshot, and an overshot always means the dog is a bad hunter!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Overshot, is he? The first time I hear it!

LOMOV
I assure you that his lower jaw is shorter than the upper.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Have you measured?

LOMOV
Yes. He’s all right at following, of course, but if you want him to get hold of anything...

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
In the first place, our Squeezer is a thoroughbred animal, the son of Harness and Chisels, while there’s no getting at the pedigree of your dog at all.... He’s old and as ugly as a worn-out cab-horse.

LOMOV
He is old, but I wouldn’t take five Squeezers for him.... Why, how can you?... Guess is a dog; as for Squeezer, well, it’s too funny to argue.... Anybody you like has a dog as good as Squeezer... you may find them under every bush almost. Twenty-five roubles would be a handsome price to pay for him.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
There's some demon of contradiction in you to-day, Ivan Vassilevitch. First you pretend that the Meadows are yours; now, that Guess is better than Squeezer. I don't like people who don't say what they mean, because you know perfectly well that Squeezer is a hundred times better than your silly Guess. Why do you want to say it isn't?

LOMOV
I see, Natalya Stepanovna, that you consider me either blind or a fool. You must realize that Squeezer is overshot!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
It's not true.

LOMOV
He is!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
It's not true!

LOMOV
Why shout, madam?

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Why talk rot? It's awful! It's time your Guess was shot, and you compare him with Squeezer!

LOMOV
Excuse me; I cannot continue this discussion: my heart is palpitating.

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
I've noticed that those hunters argue most who know least.

LOMOV
Madam, please be silent.... My heart is going to pieces....
(Shouts)
Shut up!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
I shan't shut up until you acknowledge that Squeezer is a hundred times better than your Guess!

LOMOV
A hundred times worse! Be hanged to your Squeezer! His head... eyes... shoulder...

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
There's no need to hang your silly Guess; he's half-dead already!

LOMOV
(Weeps)
Shut up! My heart's bursting!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
I shan't shut up.

Enter CHUBUKOV.

CHUBUKOV
What's the matter now?

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Papa, tell us truly, which is the better dog, our Squeezer or his Guess.

LOMOV
Stepan Stepanovitch, I implore you to tell me just one thing: is your Squeezer overshot or not? Yes or no?

CHUBUKOV
And suppose he is? What does it matter? He's the best dog in the district for all that, and so on.

LOMOV
But isn't my Guess better? Really, now?

CHUBUKOV
Don't excite yourself, my precious one.... Allow me.... Your Guess certainly has his good points.... He's pure-bred, firm on his feet, has well-sprung ribs, and all that. But, my dear man, if you want to know the truth, that dog has two defects: he's old and he's short in the muzzle.

LOMOV
Excuse me, my heart.... Let's take the facts.... You will remember that on the Marusinsky hunt my Guess ran neck-and-neck with the Count's dog, while your Squeezer was left a whole verst behind.

CHUBUKOV
He got left behind because the Count's whipper-in hit him with his whip.

LOMOV
And with good reason. The dogs are running after a fox, when Squeezer goes and starts worrying a sheep!

CHUBUKOV
It's not true!... My dear fellow, I'm very liable to lose my temper, and so, just because of that, let's stop arguing. You started because everybody is always jealous of everybody else's dogs. Yes, we're all like that! You too, sir, aren't blameless! You no sooner notice that some dog is better than your Guess than you begin with this, that... and the other... and all that.... I remember everything!

LOMOV
I remember too!

CHUBUKOV
(Teasing him)
I remember, too.... What do you remember?

LOMOV
My heart... my foot's gone to sleep.... I can't...

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
(Teasing)
My heart.... What sort of a hunter are you? You ought to go and lie on the kitchen oven and catch blackbeetles, not go after foxes! My heart!

CHUBUKOV
Yes really, what sort of a hunter are you, anyway? You ought to sit at home with your palpitations, and not go tracking animals. You could go hunting, but you only go to argue with people and interfere with their dogs and so on. Let's change the subject in case I lose my temper. You're not a hunter at all, anyway!

LOMOV
And are you a hunter? You only go hunting to get in with the Count and to intrigue.... Oh, my heart!... You're an intriguer!

CHUBUKOV
What? I an intriguer?
(Shouts)
Shut up!

LOMOV
Intriguer!

CHUBUKOV
Boy! Pup!

LOMOV
Old rat! Jesuit!

CHUBUKOV
Shut up or I'll shoot you like a partridge! You fool!

LOMOV
Everybody knows that—oh my heart!—your late wife used to beat you.... My feet... temples... sparks.... I fall, I fall!

CHUBUKOV
And you're under the slipper of your housekeeper!

LOMOV
There, there, there... my heart's burst! My shoulder's come off.... Where is my shoulder? I die.
(Falls into an armchair)
A doctor!

Faints.

CHUBUKOV
Boy! Milksop! Fool! I'm sick!
(Drinks water)
Sick!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
What sort of a hunter are you? You can't even sit on a horse!
(To her father)
Papa, what's the matter with him? Papa! Look, papa!
(Screams)
Ivan Vassilevitch! He's dead!

CHUBUKOV
I'm sick!... I can't breathe!... Air!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
He's dead.
(Pulls LOMOV'S sleeve)
Ivan Vassilevitch! Ivan Vassilevitch! What have you done to me? He's dead.
(Falls into an armchair)
A doctor, a doctor!

Hysterics.

CHUBUKOV
Oh!... What is it? What's the matter?

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
(Wails)
He's dead... dead!

CHUBUKOV
Who's dead?
(Looks at LOMOV)
So he is! My word! Water! A doctor!
(Lifts a tumbler to LOMOV'S mouth)
Drink this!... No, he doesn't drink.... It means he's dead, and all that.... I'm the most unhappy of men! Why don't I put a bullet into my brain? Why haven't I cut my throat yet? What am I waiting for? Give me a knife! Give me a pistol!
(LOMOV moves)
He seems to be coming round.... Drink some water! That's right....

LOMOV
I see stars... mist.... Where am I?

CHUBUKOV
Hurry up and get married and—well, to the devil with you! She's willing!
(He puts LOMOV'S hand into his daughter's)
She's willing and all that. I give you my blessing and so on. Only leave me in peace!

LOMOV
(Getting up)
Eh? What? To whom?

CHUBUKOV
She's willing! Well? Kiss and be damned to you!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
(Wails)
He's alive... Yes, yes, I'm willing....

CHUBUKOV
Kiss each other!

LOMOV
Eh? Kiss whom?
(They kiss)
Very nice, too. Excuse me, what's it all about? Oh, now I understand... my heart... stars... I'm happy. Natalya Stepanovna....
(Kisses her hand)
My foot's gone to sleep....

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
I... I'm happy too....

CHUBUKOV
What a weight off my shoulders.... Ouf!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
But... still you will admit now that Guess is worse than Squeezer.

LOMOV
Better!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Worse!

CHUBUKOV
Well, that's a way to start your family bliss! Have some champagne!

LOMOV
He’s better!

NATALYA STEPANOVNA
Worse! worse! worse!

CHUBUKOV
(Trying to shout her down)
Champagne! Champagne!

CURTAIN.